

the rest? What sets your business apart? What will compel a customer to use you over someone else?

My USP was powerful: No-risk advertising. If we send you nothing, you pay nothing. Advertisers joined by the truckload because they were tired of advertising with the Yellow Pages, which offered this risk proposition: “Pay us \$5,000 upfront, then hope and pray.” I exposed a pain-point and fixed it. Our carpet cleaner had no USP. Nothing set him apart, as he might as well just been a lonely grain of rice in a 50-pound bag of feed.

USPs are the building blocks to brands and can compensate for higher prices or even an inferior product! FedEx was introduced to the world when it said, “When your package absolutely positively has to be there overnight.” M&M’s said, “The milk chocolate melts in your mouth, not in your hand.” Notice how these USPs target benefits. I don’t like Domino’s Pizza (despite once being employed by them), and yet that didn’t stop them from building a pizza empire based on the USP of “delivered to your door in 30 minutes or less—or it’s free.” Domino’s identified the need: Pizza delivery was a long ordeal. They solved it, branded it, and the rest is history. How did Domino’s infiltrate such a crowded marketplace and succeed? Branding and marketing—the QUEEN in the chess game.

DEVELOPING YOUR USP

How do you develop a solid USP for your company? There are five simple steps.

Step 1: Uncover the Benefit(s)

Get into business for the right reason: to solve a problem or a need. That creates your first USP. If you are already in business, find the greatest benefit of your product, one that sets it apart from the competition. Do this with your customer in mind. Think about their needs and what they want.

Step 2: Be Unique

The objective of a USP is to be unique when compared to the alternatives. This impregnates the consumer with a logical argument for choosing your company, because, without your company, they are forgoing the benefit. USPs should use powerful action verbs that create desire and urgency. “Lose weight” should be changed to “Obliterate fat” or “Shred pounds.” “Grow your business” should be dropped in favor of “Explode revenues” or “Shatter sales records.”

The uniqueness of your USP creates a consumer divergence when it comes to their buying decision. If you pick a Mac over a PC, you are choosing safety, speed, and reliability over viruses and bloatware.